

State Agency Promising Practice

TOPIC:
Funding and
Service Contracting

Oklahoma: Using Funding to Improve Integrated Employment Services

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Project Background

The Impact of State Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities Agency Employment Contracting Methods and Service Payment Rates on Employment for Individuals with Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities (IDD) is a project of the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston. The goal of this project is to explore how state IDD agencies' contracting and payment methods supported the use of innovative employment services, access to assistive technology, or improvements in the employment services workforce to ensure access to high-quality employment services. To explore this topic, we have selected eight states whose IDD agency and/or Medicaid Authority developed and implemented financing strategies that reflect the factors of interest.

Introduction

Oklahoma has implemented a policy environment to improve integrated employment outcomes for individuals with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD). The state has used a multipronged approach, including forging strategic alliances, strategically modifying policies, and exploring new sources for funding to ensure people with IDD are prepared for today's job opportunities. Despite encountering challenges, including the scarcity of resources to encourage innovation, initial reluctance from community rehabilitation providers (CRPs), and the challenges presented by the state's predominantly rural job market, Oklahoma has focused on becoming a leader in the development and implementation of innovative strategies to improve employment outcomes for people with IDD.

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State Initiatives and Strategic Implementation

Oklahoma's IDD agency advocates for independence and innovation to improve employment services and outcomes for people with IDD. Their vision includes a strategic plan currently under development to overhaul current processes, promote engagement with the business community, and expand self-employment and telework opportunities for people with IDD. Recognizing that individuals with IDD will need support to develop the skills to participate in the modern economy, the state has already begun efforts to enhance access to and training for the use of technology in the workplace.

Oklahoma's Home and Community Based Services (HCBS) Waivers for adults with IDD recognize the need for people with IDD to use and access technology in their daily lives. The state's waivers allow for the delivery of services through remote support, and efforts are underway to ensure that CRPs and case managers understand the benefit of using this service delivery method.

Addressing the knowledge gap within the CRP community on why and how to use technology and delivery services remotely has required the state IDD agency to offer both training and technical assistance. State IDD agency staff have worked to build a foundation of



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trust and understanding, ensuring that CRP staff are comfortable and confident in the efficacy of remote services and the use of technology.

In preparing people with IDD for the modern workforce, the state IDD agency has actively sought to strengthen their partnerships with the state's vocational rehabilitation agency and the Oklahoma Department of Commerce. The goal in deepening these partnerships is to create opportunities for people with IDD to participate in apprenticeship programs and strengthen business connections, particularly in the rural areas of Oklahoma where there may be limited economic opportunities within an individual's community.

Impact

To ensure individuals with IDD can obtain high-quality integrated employment outcomes, Oklahoma has expanded access to technology and remote service delivery within its Medicaid HCBS Waivers. Oklahoma has also offered training and technical assistance to ensure that people with IDD are served by CRPs who have staff skilled at integrating these strategies into their employment services. Oklahoma is committed to bridging the gap between the technology skills required of the modern labor market and the need for individuals with IDD to have on-the-job training for these jobs. This has led to the development of a deeper partnership with the state's VR agency and a new partnership with the state's Department of Commerce, ultimately leading to better and more employment opportunities.

Challenges, Opportunities, and Future Directions

Oklahoma's IDD agency continues to scale-up their training and technical assistance efforts to CRPs on the remote delivery of integrated employment services. The state IDD agency continues to look for additional sources of funds to increase the capacity of employment specialists and CRPs to use technology in the workplace. Advocates in Oklahoma also continue to educate policymakers on the anticipated benefits of increasing the use of technology in the workplace as a strategy to facilitate the state's economic growth.

Conclusion

Oklahoma's actions to support the use of technology to enhance employment opportunities for individuals with IDD is characterized by a commitment to strategic planning, a willingness to modify policy, and the cultivation of partnerships to leverage resources and expertise. Oklahoma's experience offers suggestions to other states looking to improve the use of technology and remote service delivery to improve employment outcomes.



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